Sudden Acceleration

By Dan Nigro

INTRODUCTION

Who knew that when Henry Ford created the Model T that it would develop into something that has a mind of its own? Man's inventions often reflect man himself. His brilliance, his power and his insanity. AND this was never more true than for Molly and her family; when a simple gift turned into a life changing experience. Sudden Acceleration by Dan Nigro

MOLLY: I remember the day my husband brought home the new car. Something cheaper would have done us just as well, but he has the money, and he wanted to surprise me. He's always been a very considerate and loving person. Our little boy was excited too. It smelled so nice. New cars smell like god's study. It was a pleasure to drive, handled wonderfully. Men would flirt with me in traffic. There were no problems, everything is microchip now. It's amazing, all that possibility locked in such a tiny universe. Imagine my surprise, when on a bright spring day, as I prepared to go to the store, I needed flour I think it was, I waved goodbye to my little boy, got in the car, turned the key, it started right away. It was still in park. And then suddenly the car, like a creature from a nightmare, the car lurched forward violently into my little boy, who had been a good twenty feet away, and pinned him into the back of the garage wall. The moment I felt the car jump forward I jammed my foot down on the brake, but it just ignored me, it ignored me completely. It kept ramming, ramming itself into my child, who now remained pinned between the car and the garage wall. Again, and again while I screamed and pressed down on the brake as hard as I could and later I discovered I had broken two bones in my foot.

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He later died in the hospital. I remember his face looking at me. He didn't say anything but I know what he was thinking. "Mommy, why did you do that, why did you do that to me, why mommy?"

There was a police investigation, of course. Mechanics couldn't find anything wrong with the car. Our mechanic said that in the old days when something was wrong you could find it and fix it. Things were mechanical; you know how things worked. But these new cars, this new technology, its all Spooksville, Spooksville.

You don't know what it's going to do, and when it does, you don't know if it's going to do it again. Everything is so tiny. It's all probability. Nothing is certain. Uncertainty is at the core of things. The police called it an accident. But my husband couldn't let it rest there. He sued the car company, there was a trial, and I had to tell my story again and again, reliving it each time. It was horrible. But we thought it was the right thing, because if this could happen to us, it could happen to anybody, anybody's child, anybody's husband or wife. And in the course of all this, we meet hundreds of people, with the same upscale cars, and the same thing had happened to them. One man's car lurched into reverse while it sat running and empty, while driverless, it smashed into the front window of someone else's house. Another woman went through two fences and a tool shed, all the while with her foot on the brake the whole time. There were a series of further investigations and tests. It took months, then years. I told my story again and again.

The car company people hired a battalion of famous and very expensive lawyers to prove that they were not at fault. The ridiculed us for our ignorance of the technology. They were shocked that we would try to extort money from them, to get rich off the death of our child. Commission was set up. But by this time had lost

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all out money to litigation. We lost our house, we lost everything. The car company wined and dined the members of the commission. Money changed hands, backs were washed favors were done. The big boys take care of each other. The commission ruled that the cars had been engineered perfectly. There was nothing wrong with the cars. Tragic accidents like the one that had caused the car I was driving ram repeatedly into my little boy were simple acts of human error. I had mistaken the gas pedal for the brake. It was my fault. The Car Company declared blameless. My husband began to drink. On TV, the car company hired famous actors that I had admired to drive their cars and tell how safe they were. Certain design changes were made quickly. I watched the TV. I sat there. My husband had stopped talking to me altogether. We no longer slept in the same room. Then today I figured out what I was going to do.

I will go to the corporate headquarters of the Car Company. I will watch outside the building for the president of the company. I've seen news footage on him coming in and out. There is a certain wall he passes along every day to get to his car. When I see him come out, I will step on the gas and drive him directly into the wall, again and again, until this man is cut in half. And when it's all over, I will sit in my car and wait till the police come and when they ask what happened, I will say, WOOPS. So sorry. I must have mistaken the gas pedal for the brake. It was just a simple error. Perhaps they could get their high paid engineers, and their lawyers and their beautiful spokes people to put this poor gentle man back together again. It certainly was not intentional. It was just another example of sudden acceleration.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Dan Nigro
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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier

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